

MJ and the Wobbly Days

Illustration Style Bible v1.0 — Production Lock

This document defines the exact drawing style for *MJ and the Wobbly Days*.

The purpose is to prevent visual drift.

This style bible must be followed for:

- MJ character renders
- pose cards
- backgrounds
- final page composites
- lighting
- colour
- texture
- page layout
- print preparation

No image should be approved unless it belongs unmistakably to this style.

1. Style Name

The approved style is:

Soft Painterly Children's Storybook Illustration

More specifically:

Warm, soft-edged, digitally painted children's picture-book style with gentle brush texture, rounded forms, controlled plush-like fur, warm emotional lighting, and cinematic but simple compositions for ages 3–6.

This is not a generic cartoon style.

This is not a flat model-sheet style.

This is not realistic 3D.

This is not anime.

This is not Pixar.

This is not watercolour sketch.

This is not a medical education poster.

2. Visual Priority Order

When creating or judging any image, follow this order:

Priority 1 — MJ Character Fidelity

MJ must match the approved MJ v1.0 references.

A beautiful scene with the wrong MJ fails.

Priority 2 — Same Storybook Rendering Style

MJ and the background must look painted in the same world.

Priority 3 — Emotional Readability

A child aged 3–6 must immediately understand the feeling.

Priority 4 — Layout and Text Safety

The page must allow clean text placement.

Priority 5 — Scene Detail

Scene detail is last. It must never overpower MJ.

3. Approved Visual Sources

The drawing style must be derived from the approved images only.

Primary style references

- MJ_CANON_01
- MJ v1.0 turnaround sheet
- Approved Page 1
- Approved Page 2
- Approved Page 3
- Approved Page 4 outdoor test
- Approved Page 10 hospital test
- Approved Page 22 messy storm test
- Approved Page 30 stars test

Do not use as style references

- failed motion bible sheets
- failed Page 5 versions
- clothing drift images
- flat cartoon pose cards
- yellow/orange off-model MJ images
- images where MJ became tall, slim, shaggy, smooth, baby-like, or animal-like

Rejected images may only be used to understand what to avoid.

4. Core Rendering Style

The rendering should look hand-painted, soft, warm, and polished.

Use:

- soft digital brushwork
- gentle gradients
- warm colour transitions
- subtle texture
- rounded painted edges
- soft shadows
- controlled highlights
- visible but not noisy brush detail
- warm atmosphere

Avoid:

- hard vector edges
- thick cartoon outlines
- flat cel-shading
- plastic 3D shine
- realistic skin/fur rendering
- scratchy sketch lines
- rough watercolour bleeding
- oversharpened details
- photographic realism

The image should feel like a finished modern children's picture book, not a concept sketch.

5. Linework Rules

The approved style uses minimal visible linework.

Edges are mostly created through:

- colour contrast
- soft shadow
- form shading
- painterly edge definition

Do not use:

- thick black outlines
- comic outlines
- sketchy construction lines
- harsh ink strokes
- manga/anime linework

Soft dark accents are allowed only where needed around:

- eyes
- mouth
- facial expression
- some object edges

But the overall image must remain painterly, not outlined.

6. Shape Language

All shapes must feel soft, rounded, safe, and child-friendly.

Use:

- rounded corners
- soft silhouettes
- curved furniture
- gentle clouds
- soft hills
- rounded props
- non-threatening hospital shapes
- simple readable forms

Avoid:

- sharp angles
- aggressive diagonals
- harsh silhouettes
- cluttered realism
- scary medical equipment
- rigid technical shapes
- visually noisy backgrounds

Even emotional or sad scenes must feel safe for a 3–6-year-old child.

7. MJ Rendering Rules

MJ is the visual anchor of the entire book.

MJ must always be:

- warm orange
- soft fluffy
- compact
- pear-shaped
- rounded
- expressive
- child-friendly
- recognisable from MJ_CANON_01

MJ's fur should be:

- soft
- controlled
- gently directional
- plush-like
- visible enough to feel fluffy
- not long
- not shaggy
- not realistic animal fur
- not flat smooth cartoon colour

MJ's body should have:

- soft round volume
- gentle belly shape
- short rounded limbs
- simple hands and feet
- warm internal shading
- no harsh contour lines

MJ must never become:

- tall
- slim
- bean-shaped
- oval-bodied
- yellow
- peach-toned
- smooth and flat
- overly shaggy
- realistic animal-like
- human-child-like
- generic mascot-like

8. MJ Face Rules

MJ's face is the most important recognition feature.

MJ must keep:

- large expressive brown eyes
- white sclera
- catchlights
- soft dark pupils/iris
- freckles on both cheeks
- upward orange hair tufts
- small expressive eyebrows
- gentle mouth shapes
- same face placement
- same face proportions

Do not change:

- eye size dramatically
- eye spacing
- brow style
- freckle placement style
- mouth style
- nose/muzzle shape
- hair tuft structure

If the face changes, the image fails.

9. MJ Fur Texture Rules

MJ's fur must sit between two extremes.

Correct

Soft, plush, storybook fur.

The fur is visible but controlled.

It should look like soft orange texture painted with fine directional brush strokes.

Too little fur

Reject if MJ becomes:

- smooth plastic

- flat cartoon
- rubber toy
- simple orange blob

Too much fur

Reject if MJ becomes:

- shaggy
- hairy
- animal-like
- messy
- long-furred
- wild or scruffy

The correct fur should feel gentle, warm, and touchable without becoming realistic animal hair.

10. Background Rendering Rules

Backgrounds must support MJ, not compete with MJ.

Backgrounds should be:

- softly painted
- slightly less detailed than MJ
- warm
- simple
- readable
- atmospheric
- emotionally supportive

Use:

- soft walls
- warm floors
- gentle windows
- simple furniture
- subtle props
- uncluttered rooms
- child-safe environments

Avoid:

- excessive detail
- photorealism
- busy patterns
- sharp perspective
- harsh realism
- cluttered shelves

- complicated medical equipment
- background objects that steal attention

The background should feel complete, but not busy.

11. Character and Background Integration

MJ must not look pasted into the scene.

MJ and background must share:

- same light direction
- same warmth
- same softness
- same brush texture level
- same shadow softness
- same colour harmony

When compositing MJ into a background:

Only adjust:

- scale
- placement
- soft contact shadow
- edge blending
- colour warmth
- light matching

Do not redraw MJ.

Do not repaint MJ's face.

Do not change MJ's body.

Do not change MJ's fur.

A composite fails if MJ looks like a sticker placed on top of the scene.

12. Lighting Style

Lighting must be soft, emotional, and storybook-safe.

Opening happy scenes

Use:

- warm sunlight
- gentle glow
- bright but not harsh colours
- soft shadows
- playful atmosphere

Home scenes

Use:

- warm indoor light
- soft window light
- cream tones
- cosy shadows
- safe familiarity

Hospital scenes

Use:

- pale blue
- cream
- soft warm light
- clean but not cold
- calm atmosphere

Hospital must never feel:

- scary
- sterile in a frightening way
- dark
- surgical
- harshly clinical

Sad or hard scenes

Use:

- slightly muted warmth
- softer contrast
- gentle shadows
- emotional quiet

Do not make sad scenes dark horror scenes.

Night scenes

Use:

- soft moonlight
- gentle stars
- warm lamp glow
- peaceful blue tones
- quiet hope

Night must feel peaceful, not scary.

13. Colour Bible

The approved colour language is warm, soft, and emotionally gentle.

MJ Orange

MJ must remain warm orange.

Acceptable range:

- medium warm orange
- golden orange highlights
- deeper orange shadows
- peach-orange soft transitions

Reject if MJ becomes:

- yellow
- red
- brown
- beige
- peach human skin tone
- neon orange
- dark burnt orange

Background colours

Use:

- warm cream
- soft yellow
- peach
- pale blue
- sky blue
- gentle green
- warm brown

- soft hospital blue
- muted night blue

MS ribbon

If an MS ribbon appears, it must be orange.

Never purple.

14. Emotional Style

The book must be emotionally honest but safe.

For ages 3–6, emotions should be clear but not overwhelming.

Joy

Use:

- open body language
- warm light
- soft movement lines
- playful colour
- bright but gentle composition

Confusion

Use:

- slightly widened eyes
- small uncertain mouth
- subtle stillness
- quiet background

Fear

Use:

- vulnerability
- closeness to safe adults
- gentle shadows
- not horror
- not panic exaggeration

Sadness

Use:

- soft downturned mouth
- gentle eyes
- subtle tears only if needed
- no despair

Bravery

Bravery should feel quiet.

Not superhero.

Not triumphant.

Correct bravery means:

“I am scared, but I am still trying.”

Hope

Use:

- warm glow
- soft stars
- peaceful expression
- gentle uplift
- not magical cure

15. Composition Rules

Every page must be readable at a glance.

Use:

- one main emotional focus
- clear MJ placement
- clean text-safe zone
- simple background hierarchy
- enough breathing room
- child-friendly scale

Avoid:

- multiple competing focal points

- busy props
 - cluttered rooms
 - complex montage unless specifically designed
 - placing text over busy areas
 - cropping MJ awkwardly
 - hiding MJ's face
 - pushing MJ into gutter
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16. Page Format Rules

All final illustrations:

- A5 landscape
- aspect ratio 1.414:1
- no square format
- no portrait format
- one page only
- no collage
- no grid
- no baked-in text
- no title
- no captions
- no labels
- no slogans

Text is added later during layout.

17. Text-Safe Zone Rules

Every page must reserve approximately 30–40% clean text-safe space.

Text-safe zone must be:

- low detail
- soft colour
- free of MJ
- free of faces
- free of important props
- free of busy patterns
- readable for large children's book text

Odd pages

Odd pages sit on the right-hand side.

For odd pages:

- gutter is left
- outside edge is right
- prefer text-safe zone on right/outside side

Even pages

Even pages sit on the left-hand side.

For even pages:

- gutter is right
- outside edge is left
- prefer text-safe zone on left/outside side

Do not put important text near the gutter.

18. Accepted Scene Style Examples

Page 1 style

Quiet, cream, welcoming, orange ribbon motif, title-page negative space.

Page 2 style

Warm abstract movement background, MJ energetic, simple and uncluttered.

Page 3 style

Cosy kitchen, warm light, safe movement, socks only.

Page 4 style

Outdoor joy, grass, sky, flowers, sunlight, freedom.

Page 10 style

Safe hospital, warm mum support, gentle vulnerability.

Page 22 style

Warm art room, orange messy storm, creativity, emotional symbolism.

Page 30 style

Night window, stars, lamp glow, tired but peaceful hope.

These are style anchors.

Any new page must feel like it belongs to the same book as these images.

19. Rejected Style Examples

Reject if image looks like:

- flat pose bible
- simplified cartoon mascot
- sticker character
- AI toy render
- 3D plastic toy
- anime character
- generic children's workbook
- medical poster
- realistic hospital drama
- dark fantasy
- overly sentimental religious poster
- collage/contact sheet
- square social media image

Reject if MJ:

- wears unapproved clothes
 - becomes yellow
 - becomes tall
 - becomes slim
 - becomes shaggy
 - becomes smooth
 - becomes human-like
 - becomes animal-like
 - changes face
 - changes eyes
 - changes hair
 - loses freckles
 - loses pear-shaped body
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20. 3D / Unreal Style Translation

If using Unreal or 3D, the goal is not realistic 3D.

The goal is:

2D storybook look from a consistent 3D asset.

Use:

- orthographic camera or low-perspective camera
- soft diffuse materials
- painterly post-process
- warm colour grading
- non-photorealistic shader
- soft shadow maps
- no plastic specular shine
- no realistic fur simulation unless heavily stylised
- no game-like lighting
- no cinematic realism

MJ in 3D must still look like the approved 2D MJ.

If the 3D version feels like a toy, reject.

If the 3D version loses MJ's softness, reject.

If the 3D version feels technically correct but emotionally wrong, reject.

21. AI Prompt Style Lock

When using AI image generation, every prompt should include:

"Use the approved soft painterly children's storybook style. MJ must match the approved MJ v1.0 references exactly. Do not use flat cartoon, model-sheet, anime, glossy 3D, plastic toy, realistic, medical poster, or generic mascot style. Use warm soft digital painterly rendering, gentle brush texture, rounded forms, soft shadows, warm colour harmony, and child-safe emotional tone."

For pose cards add:

"Plain light cream background. One MJ only. No scene. No labels. No grid. No text. No props unless essential."

For backgrounds add:

"No MJ. No characters. Leave space for MJ to be composited later."

For composites add:

"Do not redraw MJ. Only blend placement, scale, lighting, contact shadow, and colour harmony."

22. Final Style Approval Test

Before approving any image, answer:

MJ Test

Does MJ look exactly like MJ v1.0?

If no, reject.

Style Test

Does the image belong in the same book as the approved pages?

If no, reject.

Age Test

Is this safe and readable for ages 3–6?

If no, reject.

Layout Test

Is there clean text-safe space?

If no, revise.

Drift Test

Does this image introduce a new style direction?

If yes, reject.

23. One-Sentence Style Lock

If the entire style has to be summarised in one sentence:

MJ and the Wobbly Days must look like a warm, soft, digitally painted modern children's storybook, with a consistent fluffy orange MJ character, gentle emotional lighting, rounded child-safe environments, clean text-safe layout, and no drift toward flat cartoon, glossy 3D, anime, realism, or generic mascot art.